
ANI

ALTERNATING CURRENT

› An electrical engineer by training, Nitish the politician has specialised in social engineering: the caste survey he launched made Mandal 2.0 a national debating point

› In early 1967, a young Nitish is said to have had a providential escape when two police bullets whizzed past his ears during a student protest. As the prime ideator and mover of the INDIA bloc, will he narrowly miss a shot at national leadership?

› A registered organ donor, Nitish has pledged his eyes to an NGO whose patron is BJP leader Sushil Modi. The BJP's eyes are on his next move too

ALUMNI OF THE old Janata school of politics have a knack for complex shoaling behaviour, coalescing into large units when it ensures better foraging success (and protection from predators), disassembling, then reforming wherever the waters are more conducive. Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar, as brilliant a student of that adaptive socialism as any other, put his name on the political calendar of 2023 with two landmark manoeuvres. Both throwbacks to the two hoary ideological gurus: Ram Manohar Lohia and Jayaprakash Narayan. Which is to say, politics as an exalted idea of social justice and equity, and as a practice crafted around the grimier mechanics of Oppositional alliance-making—for best effect, built up to an ecstatic crescendo.

Those who follow this playbook are always trying to recreate 1977. V.P. Singh did that in 1989, when a slogan actually said "VP is JP". In 2023, after nearly three decades as a self-actualised entity in Bihar, Nitish has decided it's time to enter his name in that logbook. Already a virtuoso at the state level at making and breaking alliances with silken timing, always making a moral virtue out of necessity, this year he took his talents nationwide. Whenever you see the grand symphony of Opposition parties ranged against Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his saffron empire, remember Nitish was its ideator, instigator, executor and first signatory.

The caste survey and the resultant expansion of the reservation ambit has burnished Nitish's image as a social justice champion

If the Congress has regained a central slot, it's in debt to Nitish's diligent advocacy. Indeed, till he stepped in, the idea of a non-Congress, non-BJP alliance still had currency. It was he who worked on Opposition leaders since 2022, brought together 15 parties at his Patna residence and became the *sutradhar* of a grand ambition.

There's another layer where Nitish recalls V.P. Singh even more strongly: putting caste front and centre of the discourse. His championship of a caste survey to determine India's OBC numbers, uncounted since 1931, has the look and feel of a Mandal 2.0 moment. The Centre is tiptoeing nervously around the topic, and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi has taken it up with equal enthusiasm, for the same reason: it has enough potency to ruffle the BJP's hyper-Hindutva at its social foundations. Nitish went ahead with Bihar's first-ever enumeration of castes in independent India, carried the idea through a legal challenge, released the results and took the next logical step by expanding reservations. But to be to Modi what V.P. Singh was to Rajiv Gandhi, it's not enough to be a social justice champion. Nitish also has to aim for the top—and he's a bit short of that, and also lost points after some recent missteps. Await, though, the hype when he crosses the state border to Modi's Varanasi. ■